

30 Minutes Expert Fonts Sans Confusion

Thousands of fonts and nowhere to run...Welcome to your destination

Most designers and artists who use and manage a large number of fonts will empathise. Fonts take up a lot of space, and are difficult to manage. Everyone needs to know how to manage fonts, and it isn't as simple as it seems. Windows has to load all the installed fonts at system startup; applications such as Photoshop load fonts when they start. The more the fonts installed on the system, the slower it runs. A lot of programs also have their own fonts that are installed without your knowledge when you install the program. This makes font management an important aspect of maintaining PC health.

Designers, who use large number of fonts, may need to use a font management tool. Using these tools, you can split the fonts into groups and load only the necessary ones. Others need to make sure that they have no unwanted or corrupt fonts, as these can cause a system crash.

Windows keeps all the fonts in a default folder (<Drive>:\Windows\Fonts), where <Drive> is your Windows default drive. Backup this folder, so that if you accidentally delete an important font, you can restore it later. To view the fonts currently installed on the system, go to Control Panel and open the Fonts applet. The default font folder will be shown. Remove the unwanted fonts by selecting the font and pressing [Delete]. If the fold-

er contains fewer than a hundred fonts, then it's recommended that you don't delete any. Otherwise delete the unwanted ones. Remember, however, that certain fonts such as Times New Roman are used by Windows, so don't delete them. Go to <http://graphicssoft.about.com/library/extra/bldefaultfonts.htm> to know more about what fonts to keep.

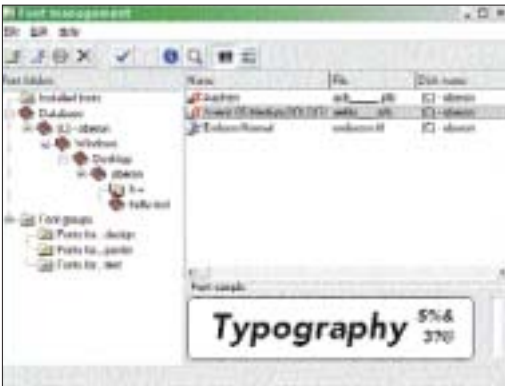
If you absolutely need to have a lot of fonts, the only solution is to categorise them and install only the ones you need. You can do this manually, or leave it to specialised utilities such as Typograph (<http://www.neuber.com/typograph/>). Essentially, what you need to do is keep the font files in different folders and load only the ones that you need to work with. You can group the fonts based on the project you are working on, or on the type of font—normal, stylish, symbols, Indian scripts, etc. Now, keep only important fonts in the default folder and delete the remaining ones. Group the ones you deleted in a backup folder. If you want a font in more than one group, just create a copy.

Now, to use Typograph to manage your fonts, open the application to see a list of all the fonts installed on your system. You can double-click on any font to view its complete details. Click on the button named 'Management' in the toolbar, and you will see a font management window—similar to a Windows Explorer window. Click on the button with a CD symbol (the archive button); in the dialog box that appears, navigate to the folder where you stored your groups of segregated fonts. At the bottom of the dialog box, select the 'Take directory structure' radio button, and click on Continue. The number of fonts found will be displayed. Now click 'All'.

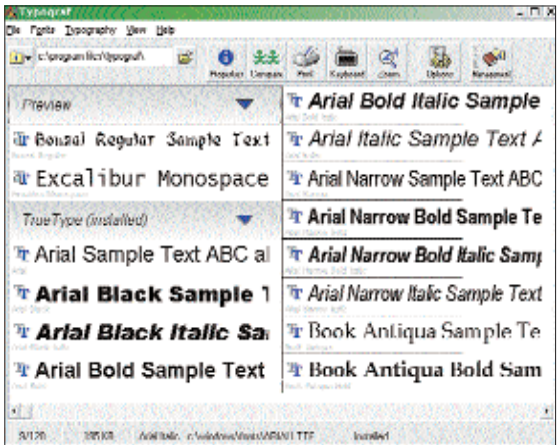
TIPS

If you have certain fonts that you use only with Adobe applications, you can put them in the '<Drive>:\Program Files\Common Files\Adobe\Fonts' folder, where <Drive> is your Windows default drive. This will ensure that the fonts do not load at Windows startup, but are available to any Adobe applications

The right pane of the Font management window has a database entry; expand it and you will see all your fonts neatly categorised. You have the option of either loading a particular category, or installing it. Loading a font makes it available for the current Windows ses-



The Font management window is easy to use, and looks like Windows Explorer



Typograph lists the fonts currently installed on your system according to their font families

sion, and will not be available when you restart the PC; installing a font will make sure that it is loaded at startup for every Windows session. All you have to do from now on, is right-click a font category and choose to Install, Uninstall, Load, or Unload it.

Play around with Typograph to find more useful features such as font comparisons, keyboard layouts of symbol fonts, and details about the fonts used.

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